

It was only then that I could see she had tears of joy welling up in her eyes. She leaned over, and whispered into my ear:

‘I got this!’

And then she began sobbing uncontrollably, and kept whispering ‘I got this’ over and over.

And then I too was overcome with emotion, and so I bumbled back, ‘You do! You do!’

Well, that’s how I reckon a movie director would script the scene . . . but you and I are a long way from Hollywood, baby.

So here’s what actually happened.

I called Bill, and asked about the three of us catching up.

He covered the phone, and asked Emma if she’d like to join us.

(Muffle, muffle, muffle.)

‘Sorry, mate, she’s a bit busy at the moment, but I’ll catch up with you,’ said Bill.

Here’s what I gleaned from Bill when we met again for coffee:

Emma graduated from high school, got into a prestigious university and continued living at home.

After she graduated, she scored a desk job in a CBD skyscraper and moved out with two of her girlfriends.

Mum and Dad paid for her bond, her first four weeks of rent and her new bedroom furniture. Yet try as she might, she couldn’t seem to make the \$60 000 she was earning ‘stretch’.

In the last two years she had racked up ‘thousands’ of dollars in credit card debt (partly a hangover from an overseas trip, partly for rego on her car), and ‘lots’ of Afterpay purchase fees.

Bill said he was proud that Emma had made the ‘adult’ decision to move back home, where she could live rent free and get on top of her debts. Still, he said, she moans that she’ll *never* get ahead.